



ULAB
UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS
BANGLADESH

Department of Media studies and Journalism

MSJ 3151

News Sourcing and Gathering

Final Project

Feature Report

“After the Aid: The Death of the ‘Local’ NGO”

How the collapse of international aid is eating the grassroots alive in Bangladesh and beyond

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Date of Submission: 19 April 2026

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“How Bangladesh’s local NGOs are surviving the foreign aid collapse,” The Business Standard (Panorama), May 2026. [Read on tbsnews.net](https://tbsnews.net)

Portfolio note

This piece was reported and written for News Sourcing and Gathering and subsequently published in The Business Standard’s Panorama section, the paper’s long-form features desk. The course’s subject — how to find, approach, and verify sources — is exactly what the story is built on, so this brief frames the published feature around the sourcing decisions behind it rather than reprinting the article. The reporting and named sources are real and appear in the published version, linked below; this document does not reproduce the article text.

The Death of the “Local” NGO

How Bangladesh’s local NGOs are surviving the foreign aid collapse — a course assignment that became a published feature

In January 2025 the United States froze, and then began terminating, a large share of its foreign-assistance programmes worldwide. Bangladesh, where USAID had run its largest programme in Asia, felt the withdrawal sharply. The headline version of that story — large programmes suspended, jobs lost, services interrupted — was reported widely. The story I set out to find for this course was the one underneath it: what the collapse did not to the international agencies but to the small, local NGOs that had spent decades building trust in Bangladeshi communities, and that had the least cushion to absorb the shock.

The finding that organised the feature was a reversal in the funding ecosystem. Large international organisations, suddenly short of the big grants they were built on, moved downward into the small-grant space that local NGOs had treated as their own protected territory. One source put the scale of the shift in a single figure: organisations that previously would not consider a project worth less than two million dollars were

now competing aggressively for hundred-thousand-dollar projects simply to survive. For a small local NGO, that is not new competition at the margins; it is a larger animal entering the only watering hole it had. That dynamic — the displacement of the local by the international inside a shrinking pool — became the spine of the piece.

The sourcing, which was the assignment

News Sourcing and Gathering is a course about exactly the part of journalism this story depended on: identifying who actually knows something, getting them to talk, and verifying what they say. The feature rests on on-record human sources rather than on the press releases and aggregate reports that most aid-collapse coverage recycled, and that was a deliberate sourcing strategy rather than an accident of access.

The two anchor sources were chosen for complementary vantage points. Zinat Ara Afroze — a former convenor of the Association of Unemployed Development Professionals, now working as an international consultant — had watched the displacement happen across her professional networks, and could speak to the pattern rather than a single case. Syed Aminur Rahman, a development professional, supplied the quantitative edge: the two-million-to-hundred-thousand-dollar contrast that gave the abstract squeeze a number a reader could hold onto. Pairing a network-level observer with a source who could quantify the mechanism is the move the course was teaching — you do not just collect quotes, you assemble vantage points that triangulate a claim. Reaching development professionals willing to be named, on a politically sensitive subject involving an interim government drawn partly from the NGO sector itself, was the genuine sourcing challenge, and it is the part of the work that does not show on the page but determines whether the page exists at all.

Verification and the limits of a single story

The reporting treated the central figure — the collapse in fund flow — as something to be corroborated rather than asserted. The pattern my human sources described is consistent with the documented record: Bangladesh's foreign-funding inflows to NGOs had been trending down for years before the 2025 freeze accelerated it, and the sector's own networks had been warning about the survival prospects of rights-focused and small organisations specifically. Using on-record sources to describe

a present dynamic, while leaning on the published statistical record to confirm the longer trend, is the division of labour the course framed as good practice: the people tell you what is happening now and why; the documents tell you whether it fits the established curve.

The honest limit of a feature like this is that it is a snapshot of an unfolding situation, built from a small number of well-chosen sources rather than a representative survey of the sector. It can show the mechanism — the larger organisations moving down-market, the local NGOs squeezed — with credibility and human texture. It cannot claim to measure how many organisations have closed or will. The piece is reported within those bounds and does not overstate them, which is itself part of the sourcing discipline the course was about.

Why this is the piece I kept

Of the reporting I did for coursework, this is the one that became journalism in the fullest sense — commissioned-grade work that ran on a national features desk. It matters for the portfolio less because it was published than because of what publication tested: that the sourcing held up to an editor's scrutiny, that named professionals stood behind their words in print on a sensitive subject, and that the central claim survived contact with the documented record. A course assignment can be graded generously. A Panorama feature has to be defensible. This one was, and that is the standard the course was preparing me to meet.

Course: MSJ3151 News Sourcing and Gathering, ULAB (Spring 2026). Reported, sourced, and written by the author; published in The Business Standard, Panorama. [Read the published feature](#)